Q+A

THE SOUL SINGER

DALER MEHNDI on his deep connect with Sufi music and upcoming projects

Q. You are known for high-energy pop and bhangra numbers. What is your connection with Sufi music?
As a child, I heard mellifluous verses from Sri Guru Granth Sahib sung in classical ragas. I grew up seeing my family sing 'Asa Di Vaar' daily. My musical DNA was made in this rich environment.

Q. What did you sing at the recent Sufi Heritage Festival?
I sang the kalams of Baba Sheikh Fareed, Bhagat Kabir, Bhagat Ravidas, Baba Bulleh Shah, and so on. Not for name, fame or money—'Bolo Ta Ra Ra' has given me, and continues to give me, that even to this day—but to sing 'sach' [truth].

Q. How has Sufism influenced your music?
Songs like 'Main Dardi Rab Rab', 'Tunak Tunak Tun' and 'Deewani' wear the garb of pop but have a deep philosophy. The Source makes me the receiver; truth and love take centre stage; and celebration becomes a byproduct. That's Daler Mehndi's music.

Q. What projects are you working on currently?
I just wrapped up the Nirma ad and *Welcome to the Jungle* and sang the anthem for the International Chess Championship. From the House of Daler Mehndi's music, there are nine songs on their way. A new EP is under production, as is my first Sindhi song.

—with Amit Dixit



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